



Organise Tasks With ToDoList

A small and feature-packed program for all your time management needs

ToDoList from Abstract Spoon software (www.abstractspoon.com) is a small, feature-rich and handy application to take care of all your time management needs. The 704 KB download comes with a bunch of plugins, and the program is open source. Using the software can be a little confusing at first. The interface is crammed with options, but the usefulness of the software cannot be denied.

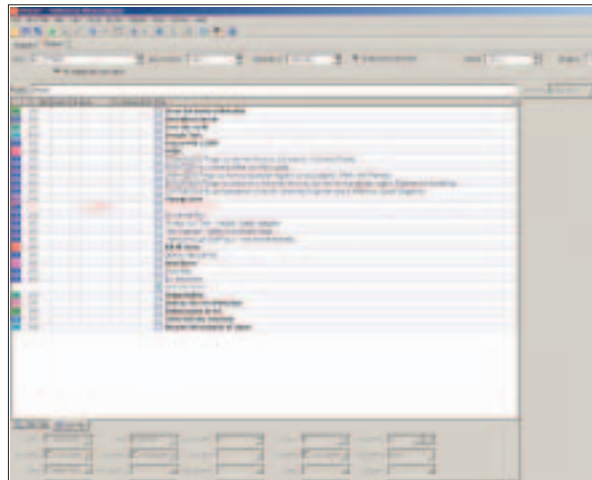
ToDoList allows you to specify and estimate on the amount of time a task will take and allows you to fill in how much time is already spent on the task. Once this is done, the software can automatically calculate the percentage of the task completed, or lets you enter this value normally.

The first thing to do once you start ToDoList, is to change the way the software handles time. This aspect of the software heavily depends on where you are going to use it. If you are using it in the office, ToDoList considers 8 hours a day, and 5 days a week — the default settings. These settings will have to be changed for home use, school/college use or for different office hours. Go to **Tools > Preferences > Tasks > Time Periods**. Here, change the duration of the day and week according to your preferences.

Once you are done, go to **File > New Tasklist**. In the **Project** field, enter a name for your task list. Right-click anywhere in the task window. Select **New Task > At Top**. Now

define the task. The bottom pane is used for changing various attributes of a particular task. You can define a colour-coded priority from 1 to 10. Assign a start date, due date and due time, status, time allocated, and to whom the task is assigned to. ToDoList can be used to track work delegated to an entire team, or even an entire organisation, not just to track the tasks of an individual.

Right-click on any task, and navigate to the **Split** task(s) into menu, to divide the main task into sub-tasks. You can assign different sub-tasks to different people in a team, and keep track of how many tasks they have completed. As and when you enter the completion percentages of sub-tasks, the percentage of completion of the main task is automatically calculated. By default, a sub-task does not automatically acquire the attributes of the task in terms of priority, due date, or estimate time of completion. To change these settings, go to **Tools > Preferences > Tasks > Default Task Attributes > Attribute Inheritance**. Here, check the attributes that you want the sub-task to acquire. These are global settings for the software.



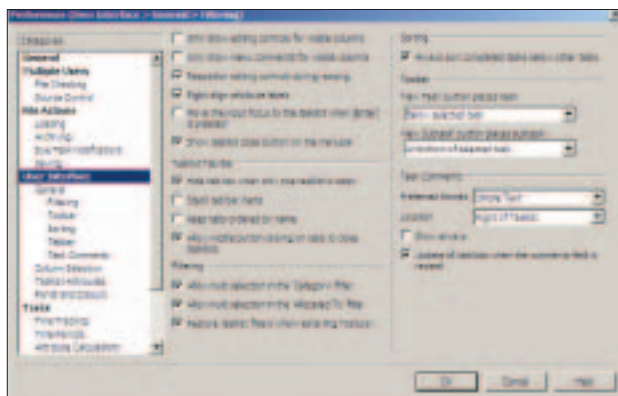
The main window of ToDoList in List View

A convenient feature in ToDoList is the ability to sort tasks in a number of ways — 25 ways to be precise. Go to the **Sort By** menu and select an option. Additionally, it is possible to filter tasks, and display only tasks of a particular priority, a particular due date, or a task allocated to a particular person. To do this, use the **Show bar**, which is below the menu bar and select options from the drop down lists. Multiple filters can be applied to the same task.

An incredibly useful feature in the task manager is the calendar available next to almost any field that requires a user to select a date. This allows you to keep track of due dates, start dates and completion dates of tasks in an almost effortless way. You can also feed in the recurrence of the tasks, so that the task does not show as being completed at the beginning of a new day. Tasks can be made to recur every day, week, month or even year. Additionally, you can set specific days, weeks, months and years when the task recurs.

In terms of customisability, and the sheer amount of features built into the software, ToDoList is a great tool for all your time management needs. Just make sure that you don't spend more time in organising the tasks in ToDoList, than actually working on the tasks.

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There are a ton of preferences to play around with

There are two views in the software — the tree view and the list view. The tree view has a directory-like structure that groups sub-tasks together under a task. The list view shows all the tasks in a list, with the tasks in bold and the sub tasks in regular text. There is a tabbed interface for switching between task lists and views.